

CAMBRIDGE HARKENER

CELEBRATING THE HERITAGE OF CAMBRIDGE, VERMONT

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Robert Murray Burns

1895-1977

Reg Wilcox, Carol Wilcox Gray, Richard Wilcox

Installment III

Uncle Rob arrived HOME on Cady Hill on March 29, 1919 and immediately joined the maple sugaring effort at Tip Top Farm. He operated Tip Top Farm together with his Dad and Brothers after WWI. This must have been seen by many as a miracle since his family had received that telegram reporting his death as Soissons when he became missing in WWI.

Uncle Rob succeeded as a dairy farmer from 1919 until retiring from farming in 1960.

Robert Burns married Gertrude Krebser on August 20, 1924. They were married at the bride's parent's home on Cady Hill. Guests from Burlington, Enosburg Falls, and Essex Junction attended the wedding. Gertrude had attended Cambridge schools and Edmonds High School in Burlington. Mr. and Mrs. Burns left for a motor trip to Morgan, where they passed a week in a camp on Lake Seymour. It is likely that they stayed at a Wilcox camp, owned by the parents of Clyde Wilcox, Rob's sister Carlie's husband.

The lead headline from the Burlington Free Press and Times on July 22, 1931 was "Clayton Rugg, Cambridge Garage Man, Shot and Killed by Soldier Whom He Had Told He must Hold Because the Car was Stolen." An adjacent story headline was "Shock Causes Death of W. H. Burns, 76." W. H. Burns (Uncle Rob's father) died suddenly that morning. He drove to the village that morning as was his custom. Upon his return home he complained of not feeling well, a short while afterwards he had a shock from which he did not recover. He died at his beloved Tip Top Farm. Uncle Rob and Aunt Gertrude ran Tip Top Farm from that time until his retirement from farming.

Uncle Rob's brothers Herbert and Burt were mail carriers for the Cambridge Post Office, but likely helped on the farm as well as time allowed. Herbert moved to Connecticut in 1942 for work in industry during WWII and Burt died at Tip Top Farm in 1951.

Buker Hill, known to the authors as Rob's Hill, is located within the perimeter of the Tip Top Farm. In 1952, the local T. J. McGovern Farm Equipment Stores constructed a radio base station and an antenna on the summit of Rob's Hill so the store operators could maintain continuous communication with their field sales agents in Starksboro and adjacent towns. Reg Wilcox Sr and his draft horse pulled the wire to create a power line from Uncle Rob's farm to the top of Buker Hill to power this base station.

A Vermont storm of 1953 included high winds and much rain. It destroyed the young stock barn addition on the main Tip Top Farm barn. Uncle Rob called Reg Wilcox Sr for help in recovering any living young stock from the ruins of this barn addition. Reg Wilcox Jr attended this event as well at 8 years old.

Early History of Cambridge

by Ida Morgan Anderson

Beginning in 1935, Ida Morgan Anderson began serializing a column on the History of Cambridge in the *Cambridge Town Crier*. Many of our readers may remember the series of 27 Installments. The Harkener continues publishing the installments for a new audience on the assumption that the copyright (if it ever existed) has long since expired. We hope you will enjoy these "blasts from the past."

Installment Twenty-two

The first covered bridge in Cambridge was built by Enoch Carleton and Joseph P. Hawley in 1832. The town had ten of these bridges of which there were three in each village. Several have been destroyed by floods and fire and replaced by modern structures. Cambridge Boro still keeps two



of them, the "big bridge" and the "little bridge". They were lighted by kerosene lamps and the town hired someone to light them every night and keep the lamps in order. The lamps have now been replaced by electric lights.

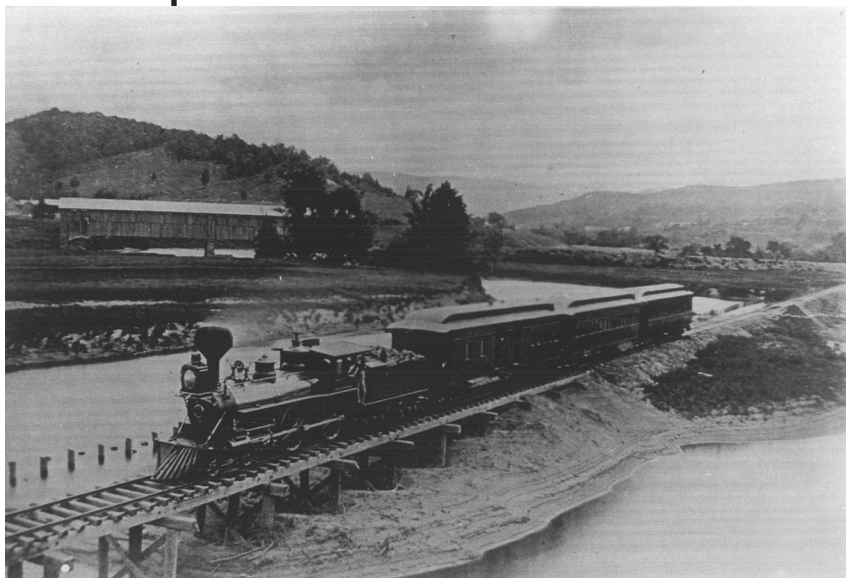
The fall of 1869 was memorable for a great freshet. Certain men rowed a boat through Dr. Salmon Brush's house going in at the back door, and rowing out at the front door. They said "It scraped some, but it would be interesting to tell of", and boats were tied to the veranda posts of the hotel, then owned by C. R. Waite.

In 1876 the Burlington and Lamoille Railroad, extending from Burlington to Cambridge Junction was completed. The day when the boarding car crawled into the village over the rails just laid, was a gala day and Cambridge was thrilled from center to circumference. Everyone turned out to "see the cars come in", and for weeks afterward the sound of the whistle brought everyone to the doors and windows. One house-

wife said "I tell 'em if the bread gets burnt or the potatoes boiled dry they needn't say a word, them cars have got to be tended to."

The first engines were wood burners and most of the wood came from Pleasant Valley way. It occurred to some inventive genius that it would be cheaper if the wood could be floated down by water from the Seymour River. So they built what they called "the spout", a wide kind of sluice set up on arches like the old Roman aqueducts with just the proper slant. Then they turned to water from the river into it, threw in the wood, and it floated briskly down to the end near where the depot now stands.

A ditch carried the water from the spout across the meadow back of the E. J. Gates buildings, to the river. A narrow platform was laid along the timbers beside the spout and a man equipped with a long pole walked back and forth and kept the wood from forming a jam. A pretty cold job on windy days. It would seem hard enough to fire an engine with green wood without having it water soaked.



Continued from Page 1

In 1954 Dr. Roger Mann installed a second radio base station on Rob's Hill which he used for short wave communication from his car back to his office in Jeffersonville. The remains of the McGovern and Mann towers, as well as a USGS Benchmark can be found on Rob's Hill today.

As children, Reg Jr, Carol, Richard and our cousin Donna would go up to Uncle Rob's for Trick or Treat each Halloween. This and a gathering at Clyde and Carlie Wilcox's for bobbing for apples and other eats was one of many high points of country living in the 1950s. One Halloween, the adults conspired against the kids. As we arrived at Tip Top Farm, the house was completely dark. Unknown to us, Uncle Rob and Aunt Gertie sat silently on two chairs just inside their porch door windows. We came prepared with a homemade noise maker created from a notched wooden spool and a string to spin it. One of us held the spinning spool against a porch window creating a loud racket. At that instant both Rob and Gertie turned on their flashlights and illuminated the scary masks that they were wearing. Well, we little ones screamed in fright.

The Burns Wilcox, and Winn families would typically rotate hosting holiday celebrations and family birthdays between them. Aunt Gertie, as we called her, was well known as a fabulous cook and consummate hostess. This we could always count on, even when Aunt Gertie was well into her seventies.

The authors each recall different family stories exchanged at these gatherings. Reg recalls the story noted above about the Burns family receiving notification of Uncle Rob's death before he returned from WWI.

Carol recalls Uncle Rob always finishing haying at Tip Top Farm before her birthday on June 20. She further recalls how very fortunate the three of us were to grow up from 1945 into the 1960s on a family farm on Cady Hill. Our parents, Reginald and Elizabeth Wagner Wilcox were always there for us. We grew up having all the experiences and adventures a dairy farm could provide. Plus, we had the benefit of our paternal grandparents, Clyde and Carlie Burns Wilcox close by at their farm known as the Hill Home Farm. Also our Uncle Rob and Aunt Gertie were at Tip Top Farm at the south end of Cady Hill. We could visit them frequently by just going for a walk.

Aunt Gertie was a great cook and we would always find a treat in her pantry: a cookie, a doughnut, or a piece of chocolate fudge. In the winter we enjoyed hiking up to Rob and Gertie's to slide down Cady Hill on our sleds. The back roads then were not salted or sanded like they are today. We could slide from Tip Top Farm at the top of Cady Hill to where Rob and Sylvia's home is now located, little over a mile. Packed snow and ice sometimes covered the road, so it was a very fast ride down, followed by a long hike back to Tip Top Farm to do it again.

To Be Continued....



Upcoming Programs

November 13
CHS Annual Meeting
7:00 PM

December 11
CHS Christmas Party
6:00 PM

*Bring a gift for the Yankee Swap, some holiday food to share,
and your thinking cap for the annual "Roberta Marsh Quiz"*

Both meetings will be held at the Warner Lodge
49 School Street, Jeffersonville

There is no fee but there will be refreshments
All are welcome.

Membership Application/Renewal

Please complete this form and mail to: Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464-0016
or email to: rgtle@stoweaccess.com

☐ New

☐ Renewal

Name _____

Address _____
Number Street Town State Zip

Phone _____ E-Mail _____

Membership Category

☐ Individual \$20.00

☐ Family \$30.00

☐ Business \$30.00

Please consider becoming a:

☐ Patron \$500.00

☐ Benefactor \$1,000.00+

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If you have suggestions about program topics or have some great ideas for fundraisers,
please let us know by listing your ideas below.

Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464



Please consider attending one of our last two programs for 2024. We will meet again in March 2025 with more programs (and cookies).

This Newsletter is one of the perks of membership, so to continue receiving The Harkener renew your membership, and THANK YOU.